



AFTER THE WAR:



DOC ADAMS ARRIVES

As you drive out along Tamiami Trail or Alligator Alley, you can watch a lonely line of Casuarina trees stretching across the horizon. The Florida traveler soon learns that these trees denote the presence of a far-off highway or canal. There are lines of these trees that crisscross the horizons of history as well, and like the Casuarinas, they betray the presence of far-off roadways and canals seldom traveled anymore.

The trees planted long ago have grown with time and now cast cool and pleasant shadows across the pavement. The canals are alive with the sounds of frogs and birds, chortling and croaking and screeching the stories they have to tell. At dusk, the chorus they send up lends continuity to the passing days and seasons. And in the canal itself dwell unknown mysteries - swimming unseen and unmolested by the world above. Occasionally a patient man upon the bank who has outlasted the mosquitoes and the sun will drag a story fighting and struggling to his side. Here is one of the best of those stories, as told to me by Thurston Adams:





"I reported to our University of Miami September 1, 1947. Part of UM was still at old 'North Campus'. 'Main Campus' had only one completed, permanent building: Memorial Classroom. Merrick Building was an old 'skeleton' covered with vegetation - the remains of what the UM had started out to be in 1926 or 1928. The remainder of the campus was strewn with 'shacks'; wood structures obtained from the Armed Services. (I hope by now they all have been completely abolished!)

"One day in September, close by one of the 'shacks' that was used as 'The Slop Shop', I found a bronze, "shield-shaped" plaque among some debris that was to be hauled away.... I picked it up, and saw 'IRON ARROW'... and names inscribed thereon. I asked several people what it was. Some didn't know, others told me it was an old honor society that existed before the War. I took the plaque to Curtis Weaver's office (also now an I.A.) of the maintenance department (under the Memorial Classroom) hoping that he could shed some light on the plaque. As I remember, Curt wasn't in his office, so I left it with the person there, with the urgent request that it be shown to Curt. That same day he brought it over to my office (second floor of the old wooden building across from the Riviera Golf Course). He too told me that it was brought down from North Campus ... but wasn't sure that it amounted to anything now, after the War. I told him to help me find, if he could, anybody who could shed some light on the plaque... and that I would keep it behind my desk, for I felt certain that it was valuable and still important, even after the four years of W.W. II.

"Not many days later, a student veteran, who had been at the UM prior to the war, walked into my office; introduced himself as Al Adler, and said that he had heard that I found and had a bronze- (brass) - plaque.... I told him I had found and did have such a plaque right here leaning against the wall back of my desk. His eyes really beamed when he saw the plaque... and when I handed it to him he really 'cuddled' it! I asked him to tell me about it. . . what it was. . . what it meant. . . what about its continuing. . . or did it still exist?

"Al Adler told me that I.A., before the war, at our UM, was the finest, highest, most wonderful thing in the world, and that he, and several more old members were back since the war, were going to 'get it going again.' I wished him luck and told him from what he had told me, he certainly should not let such a fine organization die, and that if I could assist in any way I'd be happy to do so...."⁷⁶

⁷⁶ Adams, Thurston, letter to the author, July 1, 1974.





DOC'S TAPPING AND THE RITUAL

(On January 17, 1950) "I was tapped at the first semester's honors assembly in the Lecture Hall. (Each year from 1947, and for a decade, I believe, we - Student Activities Office - had an honors assembly each semester . . . about mid-morning.) I was told that I was the first honorary IA ever tapped after being on campus for only three years. I was and still am grateful . . . You know! Surprised!!! Indeed I was . . . for I thought the tribe took only students, and, quite rarely some faculty or administration member who had been at the UM since its beginning.

During the three years before I was tapped, I did assist the few members: places for them to meet, if they desired; helping then get the engraving on the old plaque; opening the old Student Club, when it was completed, at night, for I.A. initiations.

When I was initiated, I wanted to, and did, see and go through the entire initiation.

After becoming a member I asked where the ritual was kept. There was none. . . only a few notes, now and then, jotted down by older members prior to selection and tapping. I then asked where were the notes used for my . . . selection, tapping and initiation. Different members had various parts, but the greatest part was, we thought, in the automobile trunk of Art Grace - if I remember correctly. (I seem to remember he later carried me to his car, and I asked him for every scrap of paper he had . . . that I would staple it together and create a private, locked file for IA in my office. This was done.)

Soon we had another meeting, and by this time we had gotten bits of information, here and there, from graduated members, before W.W. II, faculty members, et al. Then, at my request, I said my office would take care of the cost of having the ritual printed on parchment and bound, and that it would be kept locked in my safe in my office....

The old leather-bound ritual is the excellent result of the diligent work of David McDonald, Clive Shrader and Carl Fromhagen [also Frazier Payton and Carl Cohen];⁷⁷ [Fromhagen's] father owned a printing press and he did it for us at cost. From its inception, the ritual book was always kept in my safe and withdrawn only for official purposes. After several years, I realized we needed a copy of our original. . . it was catching hell by its handling during the initiations over the years ... and once was misplaced for several weeks by a faculty I. A., in his desk drawer, who had forgotten where he put it after an initiation. The tribe

⁷⁷ The old ritual book reads: "Written and compiled in 1950 by Carl Fromhagen, Jr., assisted by Clive Shrader, Frazier Payton, and Carl Cohen."





okayed my having the copy made, and I believe Carl's father made this for us too."⁷⁸



DOC AND DR. ASHE

When I became a member, I learned how badly off we were financially, only a very few old, dirty jackets, no place to display our plaque (that was almost lost), no money whatsoever, etc. I went to Dr. Ashe and asked him if he would not appropriate some money for the tribe. I told him of our plight, and told him about my taking care of such items as plaque engraving, the printing of our first recorded ritual that he had just signed, etc. He said that, as I knew, 'Money was the shortest thing we had,' and couldn't I continue to help the tribe from my account? I told him I'd be most happy to do so. . . but, if I ran a little over my austere budget, would he see that it was 'sweetened' just a little bit? He said, 'You know, that's the way we'll handle it. That group (or that tribe) is dear to my heart!' (It's been so long, that I'm not sure I'm quoting him verbatim but, at any rate, the concept is there.) So, that's the way I.A. was assisted financially over quite a few years - even though frugally, as we all had to live! But far better than struggling with nothing!

After my talk with Dr. Ashe, we immediately got 'a few' new I.A. jackets to add to the old, very few jackets - recently dry-cleaned! No one owned a jacket - All belonged to the tribe!"⁷⁹

⁷⁸ Adams, Thurston, as above.

⁷⁹ Ibid.





THE TRADITION PROSPERS

Looking back, it is an incredible coincidence that so many creative personalities should come together at the same moment in time and space to build on the Iron Arrow tradition. The period from 1947 to 1951 was the first major burst of activity in consolidating and building the Iron Arrow since its founding year. It seems as if this eruption has occurred three times in the history of the tribe: first at the founding, second in this early post-war period, and third, from 1968 to the present. Perhaps the coincidence was sparked by some individual personality each time; but I suspect that may not be the case, it may be that these storms of activity are an expression of an organization's instinct of self-preservation. During each of these periods, impersonal, external forces were strong enough to have snuffed out the heartbeat of the drum or the last glowing embers of the tribal fire. Faced with such powers arrayed against their fragile organization, the members strove not only to defend it, but to build its strength so that the future would be secure. Against this background, let us return to 1948.

That early spring, two important events occurred. Clive Shrader was tapped into Iron Arrow and Marvin Green was elected Chief. Clive recalls no big initiation, "...just a small dinner party at the Dixie Belle Restaurant on South Dixie Highway (since burned down)."⁸⁰

"We determined to rejuvenate the society to the active group which Dr. Ashe had originally envisioned, and a position which the society had held prior to World War II."⁸¹ Numerous meetings were held over the next two years.

The tribe sent out calls for help to members from years gone by. The response was overwhelming. Shrader remembers that Houghtaling came back to the campus night after night, meeting with us and recalling the names of previous members, the ritual of initiation, the basis for selection, etc. There were many others who helped out also, such as Lloyd Solie, Jimmie Henderson, Eddie Dunn, Walt Kichefski, Bunny Lovett, Hal Schuler, John McGuire and Frazier Payton."⁸² The research took up "the better part of the year" and was conducted by student members of the period, including Marvin Green, Carl Fromhagen, Art Grace, Holmes Braddock, Lory Snipes, and Frank Stokes.

The combined efforts of these men began to have quick and immediate results. They obtained a large new tapping drum to replace, and thus help to preserve, the original tom-tom which showed the scars and strains of age. According to Fromhagen, the new orange drum "... used in the Iron Arrow initiation was purchased just prior to my becoming a member and I think Clive Shrader

⁸⁰ Shrader, Clive, letter to the author, February 17, 1975.

⁸¹ Ibid.

⁸² Ibid.





had something to do with that.”⁸³

This period also gave Iron Arrow an artistic new letterhead logo designed for the society’s use on its correspondence and membership certificates. Consisting of a Seminole patchwork jacket, an arrow and a drum, the logo drew together the disparate symbols of the society into a single, striking design. The art work was done by Lory Snipes, later an editor of the 1951 *Ibis* and 1950-51 Chief of Iron Arrow, at a time when he had no knowledge of Iron Arrow’s existence or his own future role in the organization.

“Iron Arrow touched my life long before I really knew anything about the society. While I was a student at the University of Miami in the late 1940s, I worked part-time at Parker Art Printers in Coral Gables, as office clerk and freelance artist. I handled a variety of jobs, designing letterheads, illustrating booklets, doing layout work.... Among the assignments I received was a request to design a ‘Seminole Motif.’”⁸⁴ After completing the drawing, Snipes submitted it to his employer “who seemed pleased with the results.” That was the last time or thought the young artist gave to his drawing. But Snipes was destined to see his design again, dramatically. Tapped for membership in Iron Arrow on May 2, 1950, Lory Snipes discovered his artwork on the certificate awarded him at the conclusion of his initiation.

The logo letterhead had been requested because a symbol was needed to enhance the certificates of membership; an idea which was itself an innovation. The idea was that every member of Iron Arrow, past, present and future, should have some sort of membership certificate which could be framed and displayed in office or home.

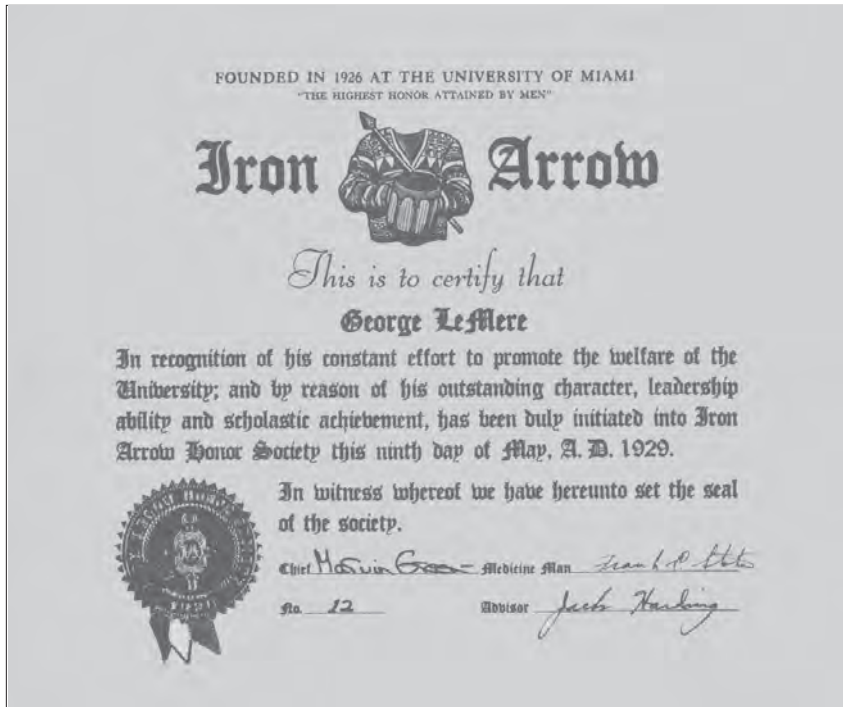
In all the previous years of Iron Arrow, there had been no such thing as a membership certificate. Indeed, relatively few records existed outside of memory and newspaper clippings. In 1949, Carl Fromhagen asked his father to print enough certificates so that one could be issued to each of the society’s members from 1926 on. The paper was parchment-like in appearance, and chemically treated to lend an appearance of age.

Both the philosophy and the paper used in creating these membership certificates would appear in other forms. Philosophically, Iron Arrow decided that its tradition was too beautiful and too revered to be left to the vagaries of “word-of-mouth” transmission. Consequently, as Thurston Adams has indicated,

⁸³ Fromhagen, Carl, letter to the author, February 17, 1975.

⁸⁴ Snipes, Lory, letter to Rhea Warren, September 25, 1975.





there began a process of consolidating a written record of all the tribe's oral traditions, history, and ceremonies. The work of Carl Fromhagen, assisted by Clive Shrader, Frazier Payton, and Carl Cohen in 1950 resulted in a parchment and leather booklet containing not only the constitution and rituals of Iron Arrow, but also the original copy of a University Charter signed by Dr. Ashe. Clive Shrader believes it was Francis Houghtaling "who helped us write the ritual, but I can't swear to it."⁸⁵ Houghtaling on the other hand remembers that he "was surprised . . . how the ritual was to all intents and purposes the same."⁸⁶

In 1950, someone even began to keep minutes of the business meetings of the organization. Certainly this era in Iron Arrow's history was different from any since 1926.

One may interpret Iron Arrow's first great tribal reunion in April, 1949, in one of two ways. Perhaps it was a festival of thanksgivings for a bountiful postwar harvest. The shield-shaped plaque had been rescued, a new orange tapping drum had been purchased, a logo and certificates of membership had been gathered in to age.

⁸⁵ Shrader, Clive, as above.

⁸⁶ Houghtaling, Francis S., letter to the author.





AN OLD-TIMER'S ROUND UP

But in another view, the spring fete may have heralded the wet growing season of an approaching summer. Furrows in the soft spring earth were already being turned by Chief Marvin Green, along with his Eldest Son, Clive Shrader and Medicine Man Frank Stokes. An April 14 memorandum from Assistant Dean of Men Frazier Payton, Jr. (Iron Arrow, 1942) announced that “last evening, the active group was honored by the attendance of Dale Clark (“Hail To The Spirit”), the first Medicine Man, and Francis Houghtaling, another of the founders of Iron Arrow. Under their stimulation a round-up banquet has been planned at which approximately 75 resident members of Iron Arrow will be present.”

Scheduled for Monday, April 25, the 7: 00 p.m. dinner in the cafeteria would feature “attractive, ‘chemically aged’ membership certificates, chronologically numbered, [to] be presented to all members present and mailed to those still living who are unable to attend. It is the wish of all those engaged in bringing Iron Arrow up to the prestige it so richly deserved, that Dr. Ashe present these scrolls of membership to the original 1926 - 27 class . . .”⁸⁷

Certificate “Number One” went to Francis Houghtaling. In making the presentation, Dr. Ashe “let the cat out of the bag” and told for the first time the story of Houghtaling’s role in the formation of the society. The audience must have been pleased with the story, for Houghtaling remembers that “in accepting, I could hardly speak for the tears running down my throat.”⁸⁸

The success of the evening prompted plans to do it all again and more often. Accordingly, that next fall, on October 27, new Chief Clive Shrader and his administration, through the office of Frazier Payton, issued invitations “to a luncheon on Friday, November 18, at 1:00 p.m. . . .” The first of an uninterrupted series of great Homecoming luncheons had begun, and the harvest gathered then has cured in the smoke from fires of 27 years.

In the musty archives of a local library, the tribal archaeologist may exhume a long-forgotten volumes of National Geographic magazines from 1950. Turning to the month of November, he will find on page 586 a full-color photograph of 13 members of Iron Arrow, wearing the orange Seminole jackets. Clive Shrader is holding aloft the tapping arrow, Art Grace is tapping the new tom-tom the tribe has obtained, and the old, original drum (now missing) is clearly pictured. Other members in the photograph are Leonard DeLonga, Carl

⁸⁷ Payton, Frazier J., Jr., University Memorandum of April 14, 1949.

⁸⁸ Houghtaling, Francis S., letter to the author.





NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC FEATURES FULL PAGE, FULL COLOR IRON ARROW PHOTOGRAPH

Fromhagen, Art Saey, Holmes Braddock, Bob Yoxall, Carl Cohen, Franklin Williams, Frazier Payton, Thurston Adams, Tom Bottomley and Bob Gelberg.

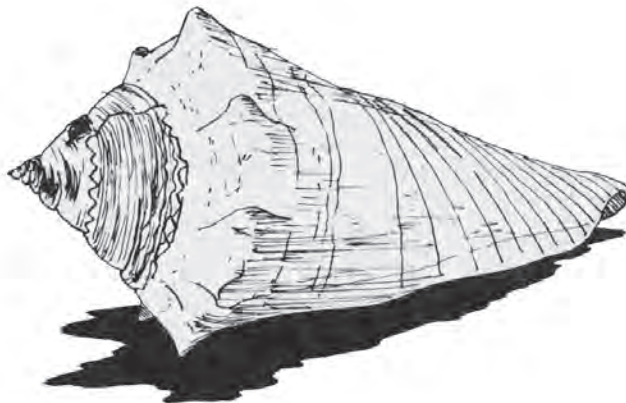
The picture was taken in 1950, when National Geographic sent a team of writers and photographers down to Miami to put together a feature story on the University. The caption beneath the full-page photograph reads:

“University of Miami’s Chief of the Iron Arrows holds aloft the honor society’s symbol in ceremonies based on Seminole ritual. Everglades Indians sewed together hundreds of small pieces of cloth in intricate patterns to make the colorful jackets. Dr. Bowman F. Ashe, University President, founded the Society in 1926 to recognize the outstanding upperclassmen. Membership in Iron Arrow is the highest undergraduate honor attainable at the University.”

Only one organization has ever been granted a charter by the University of Miami: Iron Arrow.

There was a time, not long past, when tradition was sufficient unto itself. Baseball was the national pastime then and hunger was relieved by a hotdog in the bleachers with the sun in your eyes. They were times when you waxed as automobile under the shade of a country tree, listening to the play-by-play as you worked. In those times, a man’s word could be relied upon.

In the crowded, complex society that we have become, a word, a handshake, and a tradition are without legal standing. Today, attorneys must be





DR. ASHE SIGNS THE CHARTER

engaged to draw up a contract or traditions cannot survive. Agreements heretofore traditional must now be specified and witnessed and notarized lest they be challenged in a court of law. “What is right?” has now become “what is legal?” Where courts intrude today in order to protect, they often destroy instead. Yet over the long term, such changes may catalyze a permanence that tradition alone could not ensure.

In 1950, changes had just begun. According to Carl Fromhagen, members of Iron Arrow “. . . agreed that the society must record its laws and rituals to be passed on I was asked to take the material that was known to have been used by previous members and establish a more formal ritual. . . .”⁸⁹

Members also felt that a formal charter was needed to confirm Iron Arrow’s position as the “highest honor attained by men.” A new organization on campus, in the form of Omicron Delta Kappa, was seen as a potential challenger to the title. Despite such fears, the birthright belonged to Iron Arrow, the University’s first-born. Just as in biblical covenants, the blessing of the University fell rightfully to the oldest of its offspring, not the youngest.

As Fromhagen recalls, “. . . with Dr. Thurston Adams⁹⁰ I approached Dr. Bowman Ashe for the granting of this charter. I was there when Dr. Ashe signed it.”⁹¹ Thus confirmed in writing for the first time, by the founder of the society himself, was the declaration, “Iron Arrow, the highest honor attained by men.”



⁸⁹ Fromhagen, Carl, as above.



At the bottom of the parchment-like page, in black ink, is affixed the signature: “B.F. Ashe.”

This charter was then assembled, along with the ritual and the constitution of the organization, into a leather-bound booklet. The ritual and the constitution were based on “. . . typewritten material that had been passed down from previous members.”⁹² Fromhagen indicates that “this prior material. . . established the basic precepts which I then enlarged upon. There had been no written description of tapping, so I set it down . . .”⁹³ Except for much of the anthropological material which Fromhagen researched on his own, “. . . the ritual was basically the same as had been provided throughout the years.”⁹⁴

Beginning with Dr. Ashe’s death on December 16, 1952, events began to gather momentum. One month following this initial shock, January 16, 1953, Dr. Jay F. W. Pearson made campus headlines as the second president of the University of Miami. Sharing the headlines that day was Iron Arrow and its seven new student members and three new faculty members - a considerably smaller group than in more recent years.

When Dr. Pearson (a member of Iron Arrow since 1947), was tapped as the organization’s second sponsor on Monday, October 5, 1953, a new era in the society had begun.

There is a line that divides the Indian cultures of North America from the imported cultures of the Europeans as surely as a cypress strand divides the Everglades from the coastal rise. It is spiritual and philosophical in nature. The



⁹⁰ Dr. Henry King Stanford used to call him “Thirsty” Adams - an apparent reference to Doc’s appreciation for hot rum toddies - a taste he may have acquired from years of Navy grog rations before coming to the University.

⁹¹ Fromhagen, Carl, as above.

⁹² Ibid.

⁹³ Ibid.

⁹⁴ Ibid.



BITS AND PIECES

Indians believed the earth cried out in pain when the ground was broken. “The Indians never hurt anything, but the white people destroy all. They blast rocks and scatter them on the ground. The rock says, ‘Don’t. You are hurting me.’ But the white people pay no attention . . . How can the spirit of the earth like the white man? . . . Everywhere the white man has touched it, it is sore.”⁹⁵

Yet, for industrialized societies, the occasion of groundbreaking is a time for celebration, sometimes with pomp and ceremony. On October 15, ten days after Dr. Pearson was tapped as sponsor, Iron Arrow joined in the groundbreaking ceremonies for a new building on campus to be known as the Ashe Administration Building. It was a spiritual and dignified occasion, and a benediction was given Dr. Ivan Hoy. Still, there was none of the Indian feeling that the earth had been hurt, but rather a feeling of victory over the land, of joy at a new beginning.

How then, was Iron Arrow able to reconcile the duality of its role? A thank you note from Doren Tharp, Secretary of the University, to Iron Arrow Chief, Wayne Whisler, gives part of the answer: “I want to express my gratitude to you and the other members of Iron Arrow for helping us out with the groundbreaking ceremony yesterday. Your part of the ceremony was colorful and dignified, as I expected it would be. I have had many favorable comments on the appropriateness of the participation of our organization in this important event.”

As the building began to progress from that groundbreaking, the football season also progressed. Soon the autumn rites of Homecoming filled the air. Dr. Pearson joined Homecoming’s [chairman](and Iron Arrow, 1953) Buddy Weissel in placing a “time capsule” in a steel vault in the rising walls of the new structure.⁹⁶ Then on Thursday, November 24, Iron Arrow Day was celebrated with the fall tapping of new members.

There were several other notable events in 1953. Tribal minutes of April 16, report that Chief Mike Osceola and several members of his village were invited to both tapping and initiation ceremonies by vote of the tribe. The same minutes mention a proposal for some sort of Iron Arrow “monument” on the campus. This project would be set aside, however, in deference to a larger project which would begin in 1955: a statue of Dr. Ashe. In a special election held April 23, Thurston Adams was elected faculty secretary and Paul R. Yarck was chosen the faculty advisor.

The minutes of an IA meeting on December 6, 1955, record the birth of an idea. There is no name associated with the suggestion, but it is recorded as follows: “Discussion favored attempting a statue and a bronze plaque of Bowman

⁹⁵ Wintu woman, as quoted in *Touch the Earth - A self portrait of Indian Existence*, T.C. McLuhan, Promontory Press, New York, 1971.





Ashe, as the founder of Iron Arrow, for the Ashe Building.”

In March 1957, an engraved invitation was sent to friends of the University: “The Board of Trustees, the President, the Faculty, and the Iron Arrow Society of the University of Miami invite you to the unveiling ceremony of a statue of Dr. Bowman Foster Ashe, First President of the University, at half past one o’clock on Friday afternoon the twenty-ninth of March, nineteen hundred and fifty-seven, Patio, Beaumont Lecture Hall, Memorial Classroom Building.”

The statue was sculpted by Upton C. Ewing from preliminary sketches, for which Dr. Ashe had posed before his death. The sculptor Ewing had been a longtime friend of Dr. Ashe, and “...donated a clay statue of his friend to the Iron Arrow members. Burdine’s Department Store then gave \$3,000 so that the statue could be cast in bronze.”⁹⁷



⁹⁶ Originally intended to be opened in 1976.





THE ASHE STATUE

Friday, March 29, was set aside as Iron Arrow Day. Eight students were tapped for membership, as was Dr. C. Harold King, Professor of History. The tapping luncheon was held in the student union cafeteria and honored George Whitten, the president of Burdine's, and the sculptor and artist, Upton Ewing.

After the luncheon, “. . .some 500 people gathered in the ante way of Beaumont Lecture Hall for the unveiling.”⁹⁸ The invocation was offered by Dr. William H. McMaster, former chairman of the Department of Religion (and I.A. member). The new tappees were introduced by Buddy Weissel, after which a speech was given by Francis Houghtaling.⁹⁹

We asked Houghtaling about his speech. “I told a story about Dr. Ashe’s perseverance in establishing the UM which had never been told before. After the ‘26 hurricane in September and before our scheduled opening on October 15, Dr. Ashe brought me into his office in downtown Miami in the Olympia Building and told me he was canceling the opening of UM on October 15. The reason was that the September hurricane had wiped out his financial backing and he had no money.

“I protested that it was too late to get into Gainesville; they opened in September.”

“He had an idea - Dr. Ashe! What was it? If I would go out and get him 100 names of those that were in my same circumstances, losing a year of college, he would see that the 100 got their first year and see that we were accepted for the second year in a college. I brought him 125 names. He announced he would open on October 15th.”

“As I was telling this, I noticed Mrs. B. F. Ashe in the audience, crying. Her daughter was there with her husband, Eddie Dunn. This upset me and I had to use my handkerchief to finish my part of the dedication. If it hadn’t been for Dr. B. F. Ashe and his determination and perseverance, the UM wouldn’t have even opened its doors, through which 980 enrolled.”¹⁰⁰

After Houghtaling’s speech on behalf of Iron Arrow, Upton Ewing spoke briefly and then the statue was officially presented to the University by George Whitten of Burdine’s. Behind the statue was a bronze plaque inscribed: “Bowman Foster Ashe, A.B., LL.D., Litt.D., 1885-1952, First President of U. of M. 1926-1952, First Sponsor of the Iron Arrow Society. Presented to the University by Burdine’s, March 29, 1957, Upton Clary Ewing, Sculptor.” Vice President

⁹⁷ The Miami Hurricane, March 22, 1957.

⁹⁸ The Miami Hurricane, April 5, 1957.

⁹⁹ Ibid.





Doren Tharp accepted the statue in behalf of the University, and the program closed by the Band of the Hour, directed by Fred McCall.

According to Parent Age, April 1957, the members of “Iron Arrow, highest men’s honorary on campus . . . are charged with perpetual care of the statue.”¹⁰¹ The Miami Hurricane had this to say in a March 29 editorial entitled “Tribute to a Chief.”

The booming today of the drum of Iron Arrow, highest campus honorary for men, will not merely accompany the organization’s tapping of new members. The drums will herald an afternoon ceremony to unveil a statue to the late Dr. Bowman Foster Ashe....

Passing by that statue, you might meditate a moment upon the spirit it represents.



¹⁰⁰ Houghtaling, Francis S., letter to the author, August 27, 1975.

¹⁰¹ Iron Arrow was charged by its founder as “the keeper of the University traditions.”





A STORY

Because the force of the Iron Arrow tradition is reflected in the confluence of the Ashe statue and the tribal membership plaque in the lobby of the administration building, a short recapitulation of how this came to be is appropriate.

After Thurston Adams discovered and retrieved the original shield-shaped IA plaque from a pile of rubble to be discarded, he recalls the following movements of the plaque. “After a few years, the Merrick Building was transformed from the ‘Old Skeleton’ to its present structure. On the south side, ground floor, we established, placed, our old IA shield; its ‘permanent’ location in the first structure that was to be, originally, the entire UM back in the ‘20s: First Society, First Structure!

“After another few years the Administration Building was constructed, not long after Dr. Ashe passed. Then the bronze statue of him was made and placed in front of the entrance facing the doors of the Memorial Classroom Building. With the creation and placing of Dr. Ashe’s statue in the Memorial Building, IA decided that the old shield should be removed from its ‘permanent’ place in the Merrick Building and placed to one side and behind Dr. Ashe’s statue on the wall. This was done! And there for years, it stayed on the wall facing the Lecture Hall in the Memorial Building close by its founder.

“During the years the plaque was at the Memorial Building, early in fact, we had to get another bronze rectangular plaque to accommodate the engraving of new members’ names. When our Student Union was built, our old IA shield and the rectangular copper plaque were again moved from their permanent locations on the wall facing the doors of the Memorial Building Lecture Hall to the permanent location on the wall in the breezeway entrance of the Student Union.

“And now, as you know, at least the fourth permanent location for the old plaque and its accompanying plaques, again with Dr. Ashe’s statue, is in the Ashe Administration Building, AND THIS IS FITTING! QUITE FITTING!

“For the record: Freddy Morris fathered the idea to create the large arrow-shaped plaque (several years before he was tapped). One day I was standing in front of the IA plaques, and Freddy came alongside¹⁰² and asked what I was thinking about. I told him I was trying to figure out what size, and how many plaques, IA should have to fit this large wall, and how to place them for the years ahead. After a moment or so, Freddy said, “Doc, why don’t you have a big copper arrow that you could engrave the members’ names on for years?” I said,

¹⁰² Note Doc’s use of nautical terminology to describe Freddy’s approach.





‘Freddy, Goddamn! That’s a wonderful idea! And I will do just that, provided, of course, the society approves.’ It did!”¹⁰³

But before Doc could carry through this idea, he retired from 21 years of service at the University to his Turkey Creek Lodge in his boyhood home of Pine Apple, Alabama. The plaques remained in the student union breezeway only one year after Doc left. When John Leatherwood became Chief, (1969), vandalism and lewd scarring had befallen the plaques and it became his task to follow through on the idea that Doc and Freddy had conceived.

William Vaught suggested to Leatherwood that the old shield-shaped plaque should make up the center section of the big arrow’s shaft. From these ideas, a full-scale cardboard mock-up was made and delivered with specifications to a local foundry. When the giant new arrow plaque was completed (in four pieces), Leatherwood refused to allow its placement again in the breezeway and kept it instead in his apartment in the 960 dormitory complex.

During the months that followed, Leatherwood approached UM Vice President Eugene Cohen about moving the Ashe Statue to a new location in the lobby of the Ashe Building, to be accompanied by the new arrow-shaped plaques. Cohen presented the proposal to the University cabinet which approved the relocation of the statue, but initially rejected the adjacent placement of the Iron Arrow plaques.

When appraised of this decision, Leatherwood made an appointment to see Dr. Stanford to enlist his personal sponsorship of the idea before the cabinet. When Leatherwood arrived for the appointment in the president’s office, he had beneath his arms the four large, heavy plaques he had been keeping. With Dr. Stanford’s interest in behalf of the historical relationship between Dr. Ashe and Iron Arrow, cabinet approval was quickly forthcoming. Thus, at Homecoming, 1970, Iron Arrow presided at the official rededication of the Ashe Building, accompanied by the Ashe statue and the tribal membership plaques.

¹⁰³ Adams, Thurston, letter to the author, July 4, 1974.





ANGUISH



At a time when so much that is beautiful is being wrenched from us, we are determined that this shall not be the fate of Iron Arrow. The greed of man wages its steady assault upon the only for the beauties that South Florida has: its beaches, its vegetation, and its Everglades. If a sunset could be despoiled, cleared, and sold, today's zoning boards might approve the project.

That part of Iron Arrow which is spiritually rooted in the Florida wilderness is anguished by the destruction of the land. That the destruction is senseless is witnessed by the shady banyan tunnels that have been saved on Old Highway, Main Highway and Old Cutler Road.

I suspect that we are experiencing a torment not unlike the torment of the American Indian as he watched his culture, his continent, his language, and his traditions taken from him forever. Confronted with the raw wrenching grief of what South Florida has become and is becoming, at least one leader I know has been retreating mile after mile before the advance. I asked him once if he should not stand and fight. His reply might well have been the reply of the Indian: "No. I am just trying to enjoy it while it's here." For the battle can only be fought if there is hope of winning. For South Florida, as for the American Indian, the battle is over. This leader, like Chief Joseph of the Nez Perce before him, has resigned himself, I think, and "will fight no more forever."





GOING “NATIONAL”

The National Geographic photograph widened Iron Arrow’s horizons. The beauty of its rituals and ceremonies stirred the admiration and interest of visitors to the University of Miami and members themselves envisioned expanding Iron Arrow to other campuses, especially in the plains and northern states with strong Indian backgrounds like our own.

One Iron Arrow member, Bill Allen, visited numerous other campuses in the mid-50s and told all who would listen about the unique honor society at the University of Miami. Almost invariably, the students expressed a desire to create such a society on their own campuses: Creeks of Alabama; Chocktaws of Mississippi; Iroquois of New York.¹⁰⁴ Thurston Adams reports, however, that Iron Arrow itself killed the concept on more than one occasion. Members at the time felt that Iron Arrow was strong and unique at Miami because of its origins; origins that would not be and could not be shared by any other University. Expansion would also weaken the tribe’s traditional autonomy; control of its future and reputation would be forever removed from local jurisdiction.

The idea surfaced again, however, in 1961. The Miami Hurricane reported in its October 27 issue that “the society is considering extending itself to the University of Florida at Gainesville and Florida State University. We do not expect to form a Southern Ivy League, but we would like to see a little more unity in these schools and a society such as this that would be peculiar to these schools might be able to promote this union.”¹⁰⁵

Once again, however, the decision was cast in behalf of remaining local only, and has remained so throughout all these 50 years.



¹⁰⁴ Adams, Thurston, letter to the author, August 6, 1974.

¹⁰⁵ The Miami Hurricane, October 27, 1961.





BITS AND PIECES

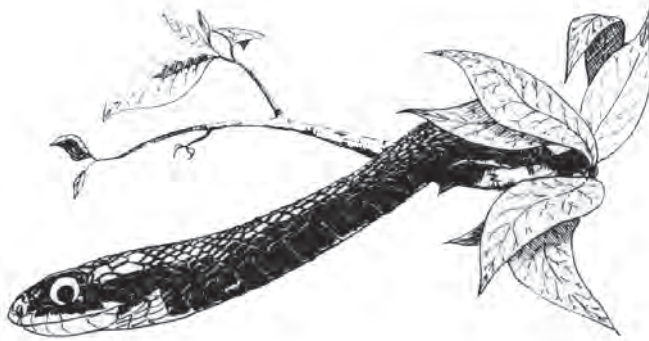
Jerry Herman was famous at the University of Miami in the early '50s. In 1954-55, he became a member of Iron Arrow as a result of a musical production called "Sketchbook" which he had written to be performed in the University's old, makeshift box theatre. He was still famous 20 years later. Now his hits included "Milk and Honey," "Mame," and "Hello, Dolly", the second longest-running Broadway musical of all time. In 1975, Jerry Herman came back to Miami. On November 5, he was Grand Marshal of the Homecoming Parade, and after that was special guest at President Stanford's Iron Arrow Reception. The next evening his concert in the university's new Gusman Hall was a sellout. "This is better than any opening night I've ever had," he told his audience. The applause was deafening. On November 7, the UM Drama Department named Herman the first Founding Member of its Hall of Fame, and November 8, President Stanford presented him with the Alumnus of Distinction Award at the Annual Dinner Dance.

Other Iron Arrow members were also achieving success in their fields. A 1960 survey by Edwin Smith found that "more than 6 percent hold political offices, 17 percent hold posts in universities and colleges, 23 percent are business executives such as bank presidents, heads of large firms, and editors." Smith's data, however, did not mention, nor could it predict, the many All-American athletes that the University of Miami would send on to the professional ranks. All-time football greats like George Mira of the San Francisco '49ers. Ted Hendricks of the Baltimore Colts and the Oakland Raiders, Chuck Forman, 1973 rookie-of-the-year with the Minnesota Vikings, and Burgess Owens of the New York Jets are members of Iron Arrow. So are Rubin Carter of the Denver Broncos, Dennis Harrah of the Los Angeles Rams, and Tony Cline of the Oakland Raiders. Walt Kichefski played with the Pittsburgh Steelers, Don Bosseler with the Washington Redskins and Thomas Kearns played with the New York Giants and the Chicago Cardinals. Other football greats include Tom Beier, Fran Curci, Frank McDonald, Al Carapella, Bill Miller, and Eddie Dunn.

While the University of Miami still had basketball, it produced All-American Rick Barry, now with the Golden State Warriors. Baseball great Al Rosen went on to the Cleveland Indians, while Baseball Coach Ron Fraser was named Head Coach of the 1971 U.S. team at the Pan American Games. UM tennis stars like Gardner Mulloy, Ed Rubinoff, and Jaime Fillol went on to win international fame. Iron Arrow member Jack Nelson was named Olympic Swimming Coach for the U.S. Women's team in the 1976 Olympics.

Prior to 1965, most Iron Arrow members did not own their own Seminole jackets. Thus, at each semester's tapping ceremonies, tribally owned jackets were borrowed for the purpose of ceremony and ritual, and then returned. Tactful





reminders were sometimes necessary to persuade members to return these tribal properties on time. The most eloquent was composed by Chief Jose Martinez in 1965: "It has unfortunately become necessary for me to appeal to all members of the tribe to please examine both their closets and their consciences and return immediately any of the tribe's jackets which are outstanding." The next year, members began ordering their own jackets and a new facet of the tradition had begun.

Homecoming, 1957, marked the first occasion that the student newspaper featured a full-page color photograph of Iron Arrow as its front page. Allan Rodberg stands behind a nighttime campfire holding the Arrow, while Leroy Howe taps the orange tapping drum and Marshall Shapo kneels on the right.

In 1961, Chief Blas Herrero presided over the completion and dedication of a display case for pieces of Iron Arrow memorabilia. Dr. Pearson approved the project which was to contain the original drum (since lost), the tapping arrow, and "the Seminole jacket by Dr. Ashe." The yellow jacket had been "discovered in a closet in one of the shacks and was positively identified by an alumnus as the one worn by Dr. Ashe to functions of the Iron Arrow shortly after the organization's founding." Only three weeks earlier, May 1, 1961, James Hahn had reminded members by mail that "Iron Arrow desk sets are available in Chink Whitten's office for \$2.25 each." These then are the bits and pieces of late '50s, and early '60s Iron Arrow.